

Malawi



A former colony of the UK, Malawi lies landlocked in southeast Africa, following the Great Rift Valley. Its name means "the land where the sun is reflected in the water like fire."



GEOGRAPHY

Lake Nyasa takes up one-fifth of the landscape. Highlands lie west of the lake. Much of the land is covered by forests and savanna.



CLIMATE

Mainly subtropical. The south is hot and humid. Highlands are cooler.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Malawians share a common Bantu origin. Ethnicity has not been exploited for political ends as has happened in neighboring states. Four out of five people live in poverty. The election in 1994 of a member of the Muslim minority as president signaled the failure of previous attempts to enforce Protestant dominance.



INSIGHT: Lake Nyasa is 353 miles (568 km) in length and contains at least 500 species of fish



THE ECONOMY

Mainly subsistence farming. Tobacco accounts for 60% of export earnings. Tea and sugar are grown. Drought and corruption are problems.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Malawi

DATE OF FORMATION: 1964

CAPITAL: Lilongwe

POPULATION: 15.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 45,745 sq. miles
(118,480 sq. km)

DENSITY: 420 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Chewa, Lomwe, Yao, Ngoni, English*

RELIGIONS: Protestant 55%, Muslim 20%, Catholic 20%, traditional beliefs 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Bantu 99%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Malawi kwacha

= 100 tambala